



Read, Not Answered

A Pre-Registered Cluster-Randomised Trial of Plain-Language Development Notices and Submission Rates

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The problem

Notification is treated as achieved on issue. The notice goes up on the fence, the exhibition period runs, and the file records the street as consulted. Whether the notice is read, and whether reading it changes what the assessment receives, remains untested.

Aims

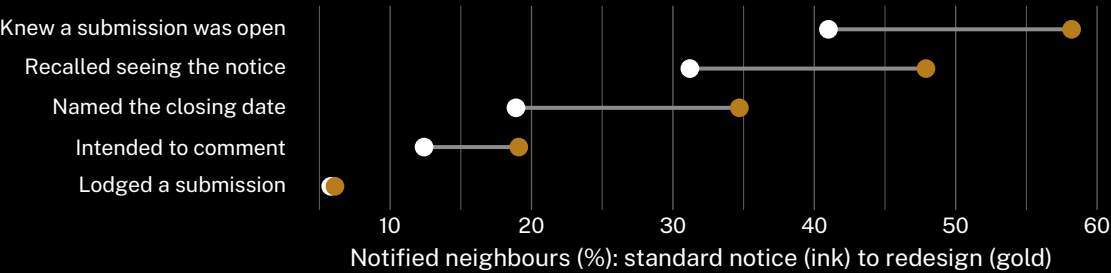
- Test whether a plain-language notice raises submissions per notified property.
- Separate comprehension gains from lodgement behaviour.
- Benchmark the program's own compliance indicator against both.

Methods

- 168 notified developments · 9 wards · randomised 1:1 by ward-fortnight · 16-week exhibition cycle.
- Doorstep survey of 604 notified neighbours at day 21; submissions counted from the assessment register.
- Primary outcome, detectable difference, and analysis plan pre-registered before the first notice was issued; no post hoc adjustment.

Results

Comprehension moves; lodgement does not. Recall of the notice is 16.7 points higher under the redesign and correct identification of the closing date 15.8 points higher, while submissions per notified property differ by 0.02 (95% CI -0.09 to 0.13) against a pre-registered detectable difference of 0.12. Results are consistent across all nine wards.



Across 168 notified developments, the redesign lifts recall by 16.7 points and identification of the closing date by 15.8, and moves lodgement by 0.3 points (5.8% to 6.1%). The plain-language compliance indicator reached 100% of the intervention arm.

Implications

A notice that is read is not a notice that is answered: the gains stop where lodgement begins, at the form and the file number. The record cannot distinguish a street that understood a proposal from one that never saw it — both arrive as a submission count, and the count is what the exhibition period is measured on. Next: whether lodgement moves when the submission channel sits on the notice itself.

Selected references

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3. Campbell, M. K., Piaggio, G., Elbourne, D. R., & Altman, D. G. (2012). CONSORT 2010 statement: extension to cluster randomised trials. *BMJ*, 345, e5661. doi:10.1136/bmj.e5661
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5. Ezeigwe, T., & Beng, C. (2026). The Reward Line: A Matched-Flyer Field Trial of Tip-Off Call Volume and an Audit of the Neighbourhood Noticeboard Reward-Tier Schedule. School of Continuous Improvement, Slop University. doi:10.5555/slop.gg4zxt

Doorstep responses de-identified at collection, no addresses retained; thresholds pre-registered, no arm unblinded before analysis.

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“The redesigned notice was read. The file received the same number of submissions.”

Submissions per notified property: 0.31 under the redesign against 0.29 under the standard notice, across 168 notified developments.